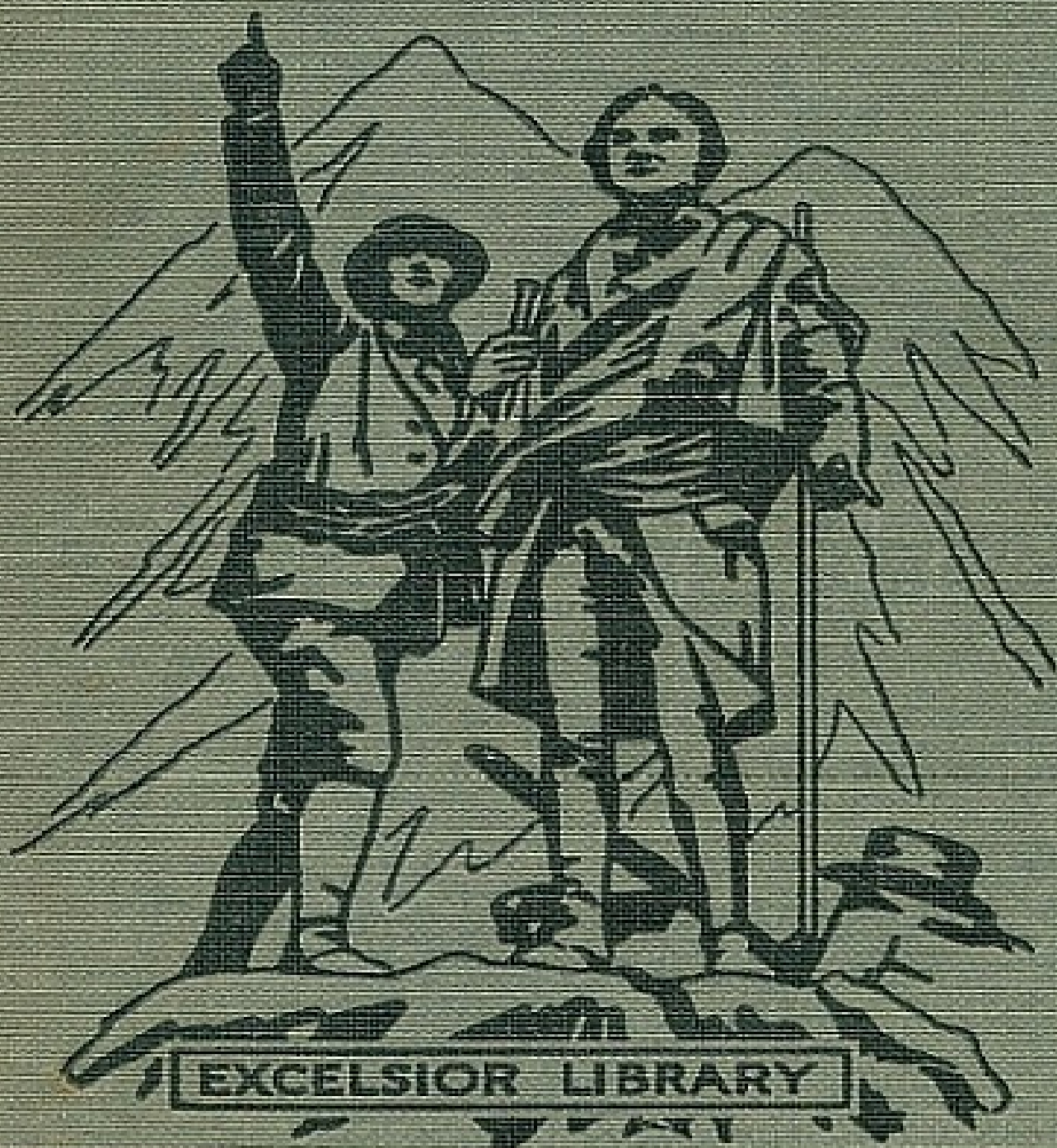


WOOD COTTAGE



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Title: Wood Cottage
or, Sheltered at last

Author: M. E. Drewsen

Release date: October 15, 2025 [eBook #77064]

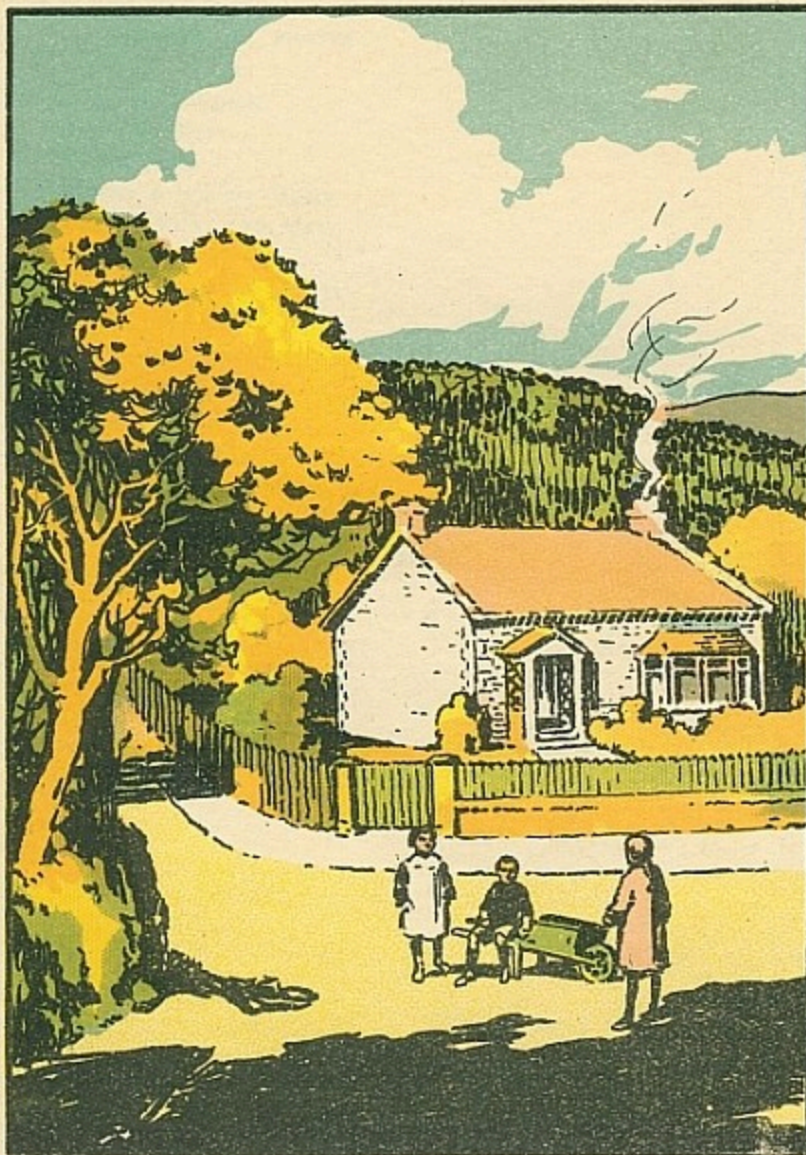
Language: English

Original publication: London: Pickering & Inglis, 1920

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/77064

Credits: Al Haines

*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK WOOD
COTTAGE ***



WOOD COTTAGE

OR

SHELTERED AT LAST

By

M. E. DREWSEN

*Author of "Ben and Kit" "Hazel Glen,"
"Gracie and Grant," "The Old House," etc.*

PICKERING & INGLIS

14 PATERNOSTER ROW, LONDON, E. C. 4

229 BOTHWELL STREET, GLASGOW, C. 2

Made and Printed in Great Britain

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OR,

SHELTERED AT LAST.

CHAPTER I.

SAFELY SHELTERED.

It was between nine and ten o'clock in the evening, at the close of a hot summer's day.

A few hours before there had been plenty of stir and excitement in the fields around Wood Cottage. One hundred children belonging to a Sunday-school in the great city, had been playing and romping about through the day, and enjoying their yearly treat.

They had been shouting and capering about on the meadows, while the sun shone bright and sweet breezes blew, and two or three hours before my story begins they had sung some of their little hymns about the love of Jesus, and then had started away back to London; back to the crowded alleys and the dull cheerless streets,—but they carried with them a happy remembrance of that sunny day spent in the pleasant fields, where they had sat in long rows upon the grass, and eaten a plentiful tea of cake and nice bread and butter, while kind ladies and gentlemen handed them mugs of sweet fresh milk to drink.

A hundred children had started forth in the morning, but only ninety-eight returned in the evening. Two of the little ones had found a new home.

And now the sun had sunk behind a black, heavy cloud which was slowly coming up in the west, and the breeze which had fanned the faces of the children, was completely lulled; not a breath of air seemed to be stirring, and it had grown hot and oppressive; a solemn calm seemed reigning everywhere.

The little birds had gone to their nests or crept under the bough of the trees. The sheep in the meadow adjoining Wood Cottage had huddled up close together. The old hen had gathered her chicks very close under her sheltering wings, and when the first distant roar of the thunder was heard, mothers came out of their cottage doors and called in the young urchins who "ought to have been in bed an hour ago."

Harry Gray and his wife were sitting at their garden door when the pale lightning flashed across the sky. Mrs. Gray had her baby on her knee, for he was restless with the heat, and would not sleep.

"See; there is lightning, Harry," she said. "There is going to be a storm. Oh, how glad I am that our darling Kit is safe beneath our roof to-night! You should have seen her, how she snuggled down in the little crib between the clean sheets, and in a few minutes fell asleep. I suppose she has not been in so comfortable a bed since she left me. Poor lamb; what a life hers must have been! I cannot bear to think of it now."

"Yes; thank God little Kit is safe," replied the father; "but we must be very careful with her, she looks so tender, and be sure you don't over-feed her at first, wife, she has had but scanty fare and can't stand much yet. Where have you put Ben?"

"In the little room; I had a trouble at first to get her to sleep away from him, they've always been together, but she was so worn out that she fell 'over' while I was talking. Before she lay down she put her hands together and said her little prayer that Ben had taught her; something like this it began:—

"Jesus, Lord, we come before Thee,
Much we need Thy tender care,

He has been a good boy to her, and his heart seems set on her. We must do what we can for him."

"Ay, wife, while we have a crust he'll share it," and Harry Gray drew his hand across his eyes.

"Ah! what a flash!" cried Mrs. Gray, holding her breath, as the whole heavens were lighted up. Then followed a tremendous peal of thunder and some heavy drops of rain.

They rose and went into the cottage after this, and the mother, giving baby Harry to his father, ran up to look again at little Kit, who opened her eyes, wakened by the heavy peal of thunder.

Little Kit had been separated from her parents for more than three years owing to the cruel neglect of her aunt, Mrs. Rogers, to whose care she had

been committed by her mother during a severe illness, and the little girl had lived a life of want and hardship since.

The Grays had tried to find Kit, but Mrs. Rogers removed from one place to another, and at last they thought she had left the country. She had married an idle drunken fellow who had brought her to extreme poverty, and after she had obtained charge of Kit had gone from bad to worse, and exposed the delicate little baby in the London streets in order to gain money, then, fearing to be discovered, had hidden the child from her parents, in one of the slums of London.

Some months before the children's treat Mrs. Rogers had died, and the little girl would have perished from want had not Ben Rogers, her cousin—a boy of nine or ten years—cared for her and loved her, and by selling matches earned a bare living for them both. The man, Rogers, allowed them to use the room he slept in, but beyond this had taken little notice of the children until a few weeks before the treat, when, during a slight illness, Kit's pretty little prattle about the Lord Jesus had touched his heart, and caused him to feel more kindly towards the little girl.

The two children had found their way to a Sunday school, and there had learned the good news of the Saviour's love, and they had been enjoying themselves with the other little ones in the Hornsey Meadows when accidentally discovered by Kit's mother, whose joy at finding her long-lost child was indeed great.*

* See "Ben and Kit," companion volume to this.

The peal of thunder wakened Kit, and when she first opened her eyes she was frightened. The room was strange with its clean white bed hangings and neat furniture. She had been used to a dull back room with a mattress on the floor for a bed, and on it she and Ben had slept each night. Her mother's face was strange to her, though the yearning love displayed there would have comforted her little heart could she have seen it right. But the

glare of lightning terrified her, and she cried pitifully, "Ben, Ben, where are you?"

Another instant Ben sprang into the room. He pushed past Mrs. Gray and took Kit right out of her crib into his arms, while he tried to stop her sobs.

"I'm here, Kit, don't cry," he said, patting her. "Let her come with me into my bed, Ma'am, she ain't used to sleeping alone. I always sung her to sleep."

There was no other way, so the mother, whose heart longed to be all in all to the lost little one, gave her up for the time to her old protector, who certainly had earned his right to her love.

"Kiss me, Kittie, for that is what I used to call you," she said, "and love me a little, darling. I am very glad you love Ben; he has been a good kind boy to you."

Kit put up her lips to kiss, and stroked her kind face that bent over her, then she clasped her arms round Ben and said, "Me does love Ben, he's a dood boy," and in five minutes both children were fast asleep.

"Let them love each other, there's no fear but they'll get fond enough of us by and by, wife," said the father upon hearing about it. "We must remember she would have died had it not been for Ben; but I know how you feel about it. Your poor heart has been starving so long, you feel you can't get right hold of her yet."

After they had taken one more look at the sleeping children, and given God thanks for His goodness in restoring their lost darling, the father went to his little cash box and put thirty shillings in his wife's hand.

"Go out to-morrow and buy the children the things they most need," he said, "I'm glad we've been able to put a little by, and I can spare you more for them when that's done. We must keep Ben for the present at any-rate, and you'll find him a smart useful little chap, I think, and when he's had a little schooling we can get him a place as message boy. Miss Randolphe,

their teacher, told me yesterday she would speak to her friend, Mr. Goodall, who has a large stationer's shop near here, and she felt sure he would take Ben and give him a trial when he wanted him to make a start."

CHAPTER II.

BEN AND KIT'S NEW CLOTHES.

For some hours the lightning flashed and the thunder rolled, but the children slept peacefully in their bed. It was the mother who lay awake too overjoyed to sleep. The morning dawned clear and bright, and everything out of doors smelled sweet and fresh after the rain.

Little Kit sat on her father's knee at breakfast, with a basin of bread and milk before her. She looked very pale and thin, though a sweet smile of content was on her lips. She took a few spoonfuls, and then put the basin gently from her.

"No more, now," she said. "I wish we might take it to Tommy Perrin, he doesn't get such nice things."

"Why Kit! we are ever so far away from the Perrins," answered Ben, "and this lady says that we are not going any more."

"No, you shall never leave mother any more, Kittie," she said. "And Ben, dear, call me Aunt. I am your aunt, and Kittie's father is your uncle. Try and remember to do so and please me, there is a good boy."

Ben shook his head.

"Kit and I always call folks by the same name, don't we, Kit? and it seems awful strange to do different. Couldn't you be my mother, mam, too?" said the little fellow, looking Mrs. Gray full in the face. "I'd help you as best I could; I'd dress Kit and little Harry and take them out walks; and

I'd chop sticks and light fires; and I could cook herrings and carry water; and I'd go out and sell matches, and bring home the coppers to you."

Mrs. Gray's eyes filled with tears. "You are right, Ben," she said, "call us father and mother, and we'll all live happy together; you shall help me as much as you can, and we'll put you to school; and when you've learned to read and to write you shall be a message boy. Am I saying right, Harry?" she asked her husband.

"You couldn't have spoken more to my mind. If the little chap is honest and willing, we'll make a man of him, and try and be father and mother, if Rogers will let us. Now, I must be off to work," he added, kissing Kit, and tossing baby Harry in the air. "Take care of her, mother, and try and bring some roses into her cheeks, for she looks very tender." And he shook his head rather sorrowfully.

"You don't think there is anything really wrong, do you?" asked his wife, anxiously.

"No, no, I hope not; but she'll need all your care; she has only eaten enough for her breakfast to feed a sparrow. Take her into the fields, and give her fresh milk;—with God's blessing she'll get on."

A neighbour, who had heard the good news of Ben and Kit's arrival, came in after breakfast with her arms full of clothes to lend the little ones till they were better provided for.

"Here's some of Mary's and Billy's bits of things to dress them up in. I was saying to my husband it will take Mrs. Gray some time to make them look decent; and we can spare these for a few days while she is rigging them up. Said he, 'You're right, wife; suppose it had been our Mary!'"

"I am sure you are very kind, Mrs. Brown; I was just wondering what I should do about the clothes, for I am going to take them to John Blair's to get a few ready-made things, till I have time to sew for them myself."

Ben was standing by his aunt's side, and Kit was on her knee, looking rather shyly in her face.

"This is the best frock Kit has got, and it's a pretty little one. Isn't it?" asked he, pointing to the little blue skirt they had been so proud of in former days. "And this little hat," he went on, taking up the black straw with the faded violet ribbon. "We used to think it grand, didn't we, Kit? Somehow it looks very shabby against Baby's. But his is so pretty."

Mrs. Gray laughed, and neighbour Brown remarked,—with a shake of her head,—that "Ben was a wise boy for his age."

The children were soon dressed as neatly as possible under the circumstances, and little Kit was placed in the perambulator, for her mother was afraid she would be tired, though they were not going very far.

"I will carry baby," she said.

"And I'll shove Kit," cried Ben.

And so they started "to shop." Kit greatly enjoyed the ride, and Ben's heart swelled with pride to see her looking so bright and happy, and he stamped his feet on the pavement as they went along, that he might hear the sound of the leather. It was a long time since he had worn boots.

"Is them your boots, Ben, making that noise?" asked Kit, turning round.

"Yes, Kit; do you like to hear it?" asked he.

Kit nodded her head and smiled. At last they reached John Blair's, and Kit was taken out of the perambulator into the shop. Her mother bought her a neat little print frock, pinafores, a cape, and a straw hat with a blue ribbon round, and then she tried on a jacket, which fitted her nicely, and ended by getting socks and shoes.

"I have plenty of stuff by me to make underclothing," she said, "and a piece of light cloth that will do for another frock."

So little Kit was fitted out for the present, and then came Ben's turn. He had looked on with admiring eyes while each article was tried on to the little girl, and his admiration was told out by deep-drawn sighs.

"Now, Ben, we must find something for you," said Mrs. Gray, as she looked at Kit with deep satisfaction, and imprinted a kiss on the sweet wistful little face.

"Something for you, Ben," echoed Kit.

"Never mind me," said he, "I'm good enough to push the coach."

"Here's a jacket and knickerbockers that would just fit the little fellow, only six and sixpence, a real bargain, good strong tweed," said the man who had returned with the articles.

They are pronounced the "very thing," and so after Ben was supplied with a cap, boots, and stockings, the little party returned home with their parcels, and the children were dressed in their new things by the time the father returned for his dinner.

He was charmed with the improvement that neat clothes made in both the children, and could hardly take his eyes off Kit, and when she lisped out, "Mother gave me these," the mother's eyes filled with happy tears.

"Let's have tea on the green, wife, it will please the children, and Ben and Kit must each feel in one of my big pockets for a parcel, when I get home. I saw something pretty in a shop this morning that I think will please my little girl."

"And something for baby, too?" asked Kit.

"Yes; I'll have something for Harry, too," replied the father as he prepared to return to work.

CHAPTER III.

A PRAYER IN THE WOOD SHED.

About an hour after dinner Kit fell into a sound sleep, and her mother laid her in her little bed, thankful that she should get a good rest, for the least exertion seemed to fatigue her.

Ben took the opportunity to look about him, as Mrs. Gray had given him leave to go where he liked, so long as he kept the cottage in sight. He examined each corner of the little garden, for every plant and shrub was a wonder to the little fellow, who had lived all his days in the back streets of a squalid part of London.

Half of the garden was laid out in cabbages, onions, beans, and parsley, with a border of sweet-smelling country flowers round it. The other half was a nice even plot of green grass, where Mrs. Gray hung her clothes to dry, but a wide-spreading apple tree threw a pleasant shade on the one side, and here the little family had often sat in the summer evenings, before Ben and Kit so unexpectedly joined them.

There was a little shed, too, where the garden tools were kept, and beside it a hen-house and a dog's kennel, and next the hen-house, where the hens roosted and had their nests, was a small yard enclosed by wire-fence to keep them off the garden, and here a hole had been made into the field beyond, so that "Master Scott," as they called the Scotch grey cock, could roam about with his four companions, Speckle, Beauty, Black Bess, and Snowflake, without doing mischief.

At roosting time, Mrs. Gray let them come round the cottage door to eat their supper, and then "Master Scott" would grow very bold and fly on to the kitchen dresser and give a triumphant crow.

Ben asked if he might look into the hen-house, and Mrs. Gray said she would come and show him the hen that was sitting on thirteen eggs.

"You must never disturb her, Ben; for, if she sits steadily, this day week there will be a brood of young chicks, and Kit and you shall each have one for your own."

Of course, Ben was highly delighted, and promised to be careful. After this he went into the meadows and made friends with "Master Scott" and

the old hen who had so carefully gathered her chicks under her wing the night before.

It was hard work for Beauty to do this now, for her children were growing big and their heads would poke out from between her feathers, and though she stretched her wings ever so wide, the little black chick could find no room, but had to perch on her back.

By the time Kit woke up, Ben had gathered her a bunch of buttercups and daisies, and then he asked permission to take her a walk.

"Be very careful then, and only go a little way, Ben," said the mother, fearful lest any harm might come to her new found treasure.

"I always take care of Kit, no harm comes to her when I'm by; does it, Kit?" said Ben, drawing himself up.

"No, no horses run over me, or big boys knock me down. Ben always takes me up in his arms and carries me safe home when I's tired. He's the bestest boy," and she looked at him in his new suit with great satisfaction.

"Doesn't it seem strange, Kit, to be here," said Ben, as they walked up and down the road, "with good dinners, teas, nice clothes, and such beautiful hens and chickens."

"Yes; and Jesus is here too, isn't He? and He gave us these nice things? The lady said so."

"Of course He is; and He helped your father and mother to find you. We ought to thank Him. I believe it all comes because we went to the Sunday school. See how we got the fine treat, and then how your mother came to the field and saw you crying, and found out that you were her little girl. Kit, we ought to thank Jesus about it; the Sunday school belongs to Him!" said Ben, solemnly.

"Where will we kneel down, Ben?"

"There's a nice little shed would do," said Ben, "come along and I'll show you." They opened the door of the out-house, and finding a clean spot, the children took hands and knelt as they had knelt many a time in the little back room at Peters Street. "You first, Kit, then me next," said Ben.

"Bless me, Jesus Lord, and Ben too," began Kit, "I'm very glad I've found my father and mother and baby, and You have given us all these nice things—Amen."

"And take care of the Sunday school now we are not there," added Ben, "and help me to be handy to my new father and mother, and take us all to heaven, because you're the Saviour—Amen."

The mother had watched them go into the shed, and wondering what kept them there, had stolen on tip-toe round to the other side, and looked in through a space between the boards.

The sight she saw caused her unmingled astonishment. She had no idea that the little ones had learned thus to pray and tell Jesus of their joys as well as their troubles. Kittie's eyes were closed, and the light from the door fell upon her sweet serene little face, while Ben, with knitted brows, was moving his head from side to side, and clasping her hand firmly.

"I'm glad we've thanked Him; now it won't look as if we had forgotten," he said as they rose. "It would be real mean, you know, Kit, when God took such care of us in Peters Street. Miss Randolphe said she would come and see us some day, and hear our verses. We mustn't forget them. Let's come under the tree and say them."

Mrs. Gray stepped forward, and without appearing to have seen the children before, asked them to come and help her get tea ready, for father was coming in, and they were all to have tea on the green. She wanted them to carry out the cups and plates, and bread and butter, then after that she wished them to sing their hymns.

CHAPTER IV.

LAMBS OF THE FLOCK.

"Before tea, Harry must get his face washed," Mrs. Gray said, and taking baby on her knee, proceeded to sponge his rosy cheeks. Harry screamed lustily.

"I never scream when Ben washes my face," said Kit, who was watching the operation with great interest.

"No, but you are older than Harry, and know better," said her mother.

"I'm growing a bigger girl," said Kit, straightening herself. "I'm *up to my head*,—see!" and she placed her hand on the top of her curly locks.

"So you are," said her mother, laughing; "and down to your toes."

"When Harry is up to my head and down to my toes, he won't scream when being washed," cried Kit.

"I hope not," replied her mother, as Ben laughed merrily; "but see, he's a good boy now, and fit to be kissed; so we will lay him down on the grass to kick, while we set the table for tea."

They spread a table-cloth on the green, and the children were delighted to help. It was so different from anything they had done before.

Ben carried out hassocks for Kit and himself, and the two ran back and forward with plates, cups, and spoons, and every time they came with a fresh article, baby Harry crowed and kicked afresh.

"Now, that's the train in," said Mrs. Gray, "go to the gate, and look for father. In a few minutes he should be here." Soon they both returned to the house each holding the father's hand, and each carrying a parcel. Ben waited while Kit's parcel was being opened, and then both children uttered a cry of delight. A wax doll with blue eyes and flaxen ringlets made its appearance dressed in blue.

"I couldn't resist bringing it to her," said Gray, "I guessed that she never had such before." Kit hugged her new treasure much as her mother had hugged her the night before, while her eyes grew lustrous, and a bright flush spread over her cheeks.

Ben quite forgot for the minute to open his parcel, he was so lost in admiration over Kit's doll. But when he had time to think of his and had opened it he found himself the possessor of a First Reading Book crammed full with illustrations. There were pictures of dogs and cats, horses, ships, soldiers, etc., etc.

"Now, Ben, you must learn to read," said the father, when they had taken their places for tea, "so that in a few months you can go out and earn your living again like a brave boy."

"So I will, if my own father, in Peters Street, will let me stay with you. Oh! I do hope he will. But I haven't made you a bow for the fine book. This is how we bow to the gentry when they give us coppers, isn't it, Kit?" and he stood up and made them all laugh while he pulled his front hair and then went head over heels all along the grass.

Then Harry received his present, which was a squeaking pig, and it added to the merriment of the little party to see his pleasure, and to hear his funny little crows of delight mingling with the squeaks of the pig.

Ben was merry that night. He felt so happy, for Mr. Gray said he had gone to Peters Street in the middle of the day and had seen their old home. He brought with him the little Sunday school books and a wallflower Kit prized. He also had called on Mrs. Perrin, who had been a kind friend to them, and had had a long talk with her. She told him much of Ben's faithfulness to Kit, and cried at the thought of losing the children.

However, Gray asked her over with her children to spend the day at Wood Cottage in a fortnight's time, and she had promised to come. Rogers (Ben's father) was not at home, but Mrs. Perrin said she would give him the message that Gray left, and do her best to persuade him to give Ben up to them, and then she would write and let the inmates of Wood Cottage know the result.

She had little difficulty about it, for Rogers wanted to go to sea, and his only drawback had been leaving the little fellow.

Ben was very glad to get his few books again.

"This one has our newest hymns in it," he said, pointing to the well-worn cover.

"Let us hear it, Ben," said the mother.

"Well, turn about then, Kit," said the boy, "you one verse and I the next."

Kit laid her doll down with a fond look, and folded her arms while she repeated—

"We are lambs of the flock,
And no danger we fear,
While the voice and the call
Of our Shepherd we hear.

"We will follow, we will follow
His call to our home in the sky."

Then Ben went on with the two next verses—

"Oh, the pastures are green,
And the flowers bloom around,
By the side of still waters
He will make us lie down.

"We will follow," etc.

"Oh, that all the dear lambs
Had a heart to reply,
When the good Shepherd calls
From His home in the sky.

"We will follow," etc.

"That is very pretty, and nicely repeated too," said Kit's parents. Do you know any more?

"I know a beautiful one about"

"I want to be like Jesus,
So lovely and so meek
For no one—one——"

"Marked" put in Ben—

"Marked an angry word
That ever heard Him speak."

"And I like the verse," added Ben—

"I want to be like Jesus,
Engaged in doing good,
So that of me it may be said,
He hath done what he could."

"Now, tell us what you heard in the Sunday school from the teacher," said the mother.

"Well," began Ben, "our teacher said we were like little lambs, and Jesus is the Good Shepherd; and He came down from heaven and died for us, so that we need not die for our sins; and she told us to love Him and trust Him; and He would take His little lambs in His arms and help them on, and give them all they require, and—and—" hesitated Ben.

"And one day we will go to Jesus' happy place up there, and we want to be like Jesus," said Kit.

While she was speaking, Ben rose with flushed cheeks, and pointed to the western sky where bright clouds were lying as the sun slowly descended.

"Hark! I think I can hear it!" he said, raising his head. "Perhaps the time has come! oh, perhaps!"

"What time?" they asked, wondering what the boy meant.

"Why, for Jesus to come, of course. See how bright it is! and I think I hear the sound of the trumpet! Maybe the time's come—has it?"

For a minute neither of the parents spoke. Then the mother said: "It is the sun setting, and the sound you heard was a bell far away—but one day soon Jesus will come to take us home to Heaven."

Ben sat down and watched the sky, looking rather disappointed.

"I thought it was the trumpet. Teacher said He might come any day, and that we were always to be looking out for Him, ready for the trumpet sound, when we would go up to be with Jesus."

"Do you want to go so much, Ben?" asked the mother.

"Yes, it would be nice; so nice. We often hoped that Jesus would come every night when we were hungry and it was dark and cold,—didn't we, Kit?"

"Yes; and Him is coming some day," said Kit, with a nod of her head.

"I wonder if folks want Him as much when they have good houses and nice dinners, and beautiful gardens?" asked Ben in a slow and thoughtful tone, as if to himself. "I wonder if Kit and I will want Him as much now!"

Mrs. Gray had not an answer ready for Ben; she was putting one or two questions to her own heart—questions she could not very easily answer.

Tears filled her eyes, and she rose to put baby Harry to bed.

So Ben sat very quiet, thinking over the matter till the silence was broken by the father saying:

"We ought to want the Lord as much in the bright days, as in the dark. I hope Kit and you will never stop speaking of Him. He left all the brightness and the glory of heaven, and came down to this earth where all was sin and darkness. They were dark sorrowful days for Him; but He came."

"He came to save us, teacher said," put in Ben.

CHAPTER V.

DIFFICULTIES IN THE NARROW PATH.

Three weeks after Ben and Kit entered their new home, Ben's school life began. He was very proud to make the start, and went with great confidence, because he was able to say the alphabet correctly, and had learned to read a few little words.

Miss Randolphe, their old Sunday school teacher, had called at Wood Cottage and given Mrs. Gray twenty shillings to be used for Ben's schooling. She was very fond of the two children, and stayed some time with them, and spoke to them of the Saviour and His home, as she had done in times gone by. She noticed that Ben looked a little sorrowful as she spoke, and she asked him if he was quite happy.

"Come up the garden, and I'll tell you," he said.

So Miss Randolphe took his hand and walked up to the garden seat.

"Well, Ben," she asked kindly, "does anything trouble you?"

The tears trickled down Ben's cheeks. "It's jolly here, but when you spoke it seemed as if I used to love Him better," and Ben nodded toward the sky. "Is it harder for folks to be good when they've got nice things?" he asked.

"Do you find it harder to please Jesus here, Ben?"

"Yes, things go wrong inside me," he answered, with a sob. "Perhaps He doesn't take so much care of me now I've got father and mother.

"That's not it, Ben dear; Jesus is just the same, He never changes. It is we who change. Do you go to Him as much as you did? Is it not that you do not feel to need Him so much now?"

"I expect *that's it*," he answered.

"And you must remember, Ben, that Satan is ever on the watch to tempt you. It is hard to resist him, but you must do it. If you trust in Jesus, who died for sinners, you are God's little child. You may fail sometimes and do wrong, and make mistakes, but you are God's little child all the same. It is far happier to be His obedient child than to wander from Him. Before coming here you felt that you needed to ask God for your daily bread and for your clothes. Ask Him just the same now, Ben. In one day He could take away all these good things if He chose. It is easier to keep near Him in the dark days, because we lean more on Him. Do you understand, dear?"

"Yes, I see it!" replied the little fellow, with a smile. "I began to think perhaps it was Kit loved Jesus and not me!"

"Just think of *His love* to you, Ben. He went straight to the cross for you and shed His precious blood to wash away your sin. *His love never* grows cold."

"I'll never think He doesn't love me again, and I'll fight against Satan. Only it's very hard, for there's a boy near here who teases me and mocks me, and sometimes I feel so cross and angry."

"You can only overcome him by the Saviour's help. Go and tell Jesus whenever you are tempted. Now I shall give you two little printed texts to keep, and you must read them over sometimes. The first is 'Jesus Christ, the same yesterday, to-day, and for ever' (Heb. 13. 8). It is just as if '*yesterday*' was when He died on the cross for us. '*To-day*' is now that He is helping us along the narrow pathway, and '*for ever*' is when we shall be with Him in glory. The other text is 'To him that overcometh will I give to eat of the tree of life, which is in the midst of the Paradise of God.'" (Rev. 2. 7).

Ben was very pleased with the texts, and said he would pin them up over his bed.

CHAPTER VI.

BEN'S BATTLE BEGINS.

Perhaps my little reader thinks that if he were a boy like Ben he would have no trouble after he reached such a happy home as Wood Cottage. But that is a mistake. When little children or grown-up people start on the narrow pathway they meet many foes who try to hinder them and make them unhappy. First there is Satan himself, who does not honour the blood of Jesus, and who tries to make those unhappy who do. And then we find that though our sins are all forgiven, and there is no judgment for us, yet our sinful hearts are still with us, and unless we are watchful, Satan will tempt us to grieve the Saviour.

Now I will tell you of some kinds of difficulties little boys and girls have to contend with.

Ben had lived very much as he pleased, or rather as best he could, in the old days when his parents were absent; and his thoughts were generally taken up with how to find bread for Kit and himself. Suddenly he was placed in a new home with kind friends, and food and clothes provided, and

after a few days he almost longed to get roving about for himself again. Not that he really wanted to get away to Peters Street, but *sometimes* he cast a wistful eye back to the days when he brought home his coppers so proudly, and had little Kit "all to himself."

Have we never after a change of circumstances looked back a little regretfully to the past scenes, though they were shady ones, when there was some little peculiar joy that made up for the trial? Yes, many of us have!

Kit was glad the first week or two to sit on her mother's knee, for she felt weak and weary, and it was a new pleasure for her to feel strong and loving arms around her. Ben, who was weeding the garden, could see them through the open door; and he would say to himself a little bitterly—"Kit doesn't want me now."

But it was only sometimes he felt jealous, for there were happy busy mornings when Ben made himself useful chopping sticks, carrying in coal, cleaning windows, weeding and tidying up the garden, and Kit would sit in her little chair and watch him and say, from time to time, "You is the bestest boy for work, Ben."

After his work was done he would put on the two children's sun hats, and take them away into the meadows to gather daisies; and then all three would be very happy together. Mrs. Gray said she found him a great help, and she didn't know what she would do without him, for he ran all her messages, and was "so handy on a washing day."

A short distance along the road was a row of small houses, and Mrs. Gray knew by sight many of the people who lived there. One family named Snow had very often attracted her notice. It consisted of the father and mother and eight children. A very unruly family they were, but the fact gave the mother little concern. She took things "easy," and contented herself with putting the children out of doors when they "bothered" her, or giving an occasional whipping all round when needed. She didn't believe in much punishment, and therefore passed over falsehoods and small thefts and fits of temper, as necessary faults with children. "They would come right some day," she said.

The elder ones kept as much as possible out of her sight in play hours, and she did not know half the mischief they did. There was one of the elder boys named Jim, who teased Ben a great deal.

Jim found out that Ben had been a very poor boy, and had earned his living by selling matches, and it was a grand opportunity for him to turn tormentor.

He would take off his cap to Ben as he passed him in the road, and say—"Have you got any matches to sell to-day, I'm wanting a light for my pipe."

And then when Ben reddened and looked angry, he would make a low bow, and say—"I beg your honour's pardon, I must have made a mistake; I see you are a grand gentleman with a new suit on."

This sort of thing was very hard for Ben to bear; he had never been mocked at before. And one day, after Jim had been speaking in this way, Ben said to Kit—

"I'm going to pay him out, Kit. I shall give him something he'll *never* forget."

"What will you give him, Ben, dear; something nice to make him sorry?" she asked.

"That's the trouble," muttered Ben, moodily. "I oughtn't to fight now. I've promised not to. And of course I want to please Jesus, but I *can't* bear it."

Kit put her arms round the boy's neck and kissed him, and the anger melted away from his face.

"P'haps Jim will soon turn into a good boy," she said. "Let us ask Jesus to make him sorry."

"That's the best way after all," answered Ben, as he returned her kiss.

It was a bright sunny morning when Ben parted with Kit at the gate, and started for school for the first time.

"Be sure and watch for me when I come home," he said. Kit promised, and off he ran waving to her and the mother as long as he could.

Jim Snow attended the same school, and as he had been learning to read for three or four years, he was in one of the higher classes. After the master had examined Ben, he placed him at the top of the infant class. But he patted his head kindly and said, "You look a sharp boy, study hard and I will put you up higher."

Ben would not have thought so much about being in the low class, for he was very anxious to get on, but when he raised his eyes, there was Jim looking through the glass partition of the next classroom at him, sneering and putting out his tongue and causing the others to laugh.

Ben tried not to look or to heed him, though he felt the insult very keenly.

The little fellow's heart swelled within him as he walked home, and some of the boys in the class ran by him crying, "Baby, baby."

"I should like to show them I'm no baby," he said to himself, as he unconsciously clenched his fist.

A minute after, as he neared the cottage gate, Jim overtook him. Ben's spirit rose as the boy asked, "If he would like to be carried home, as he was in the baby class; he surely was not fit to walk alone."

"Be off, and stop your nonsense," said Ben, "or I will pay you back."

Jim went on with his teasing talk, and Ben, forgetting all his good resolutions, flew at him. Of course, Jim returned the blow, and so blow for blow was given, and for a minute the boys fought.

Ben was strong and fearless, but Jim was the bigger, though he was not nearly so brave, and he might have given in, but a cry from the gate of

Wood Cottage recalled Ben to his senses, and at the same moment a hand was laid on his shoulder. A lady stood before the boys, saying, "Shame on you both, are you not afraid to stand fighting there with the eye of God looking upon you? and you are too big to strike such a little boy," she said, looking at Jim. Ben's eyes turned towards the gate where Kit was standing with a distressed face. She had stopped screaming when they left off fighting, and now her arms were spread out appealingly to Ben.

Jim slunk off, muttering angry words. He was rather glad to escape, for his courage had nearly forsaken him, but, as he turned to go, Ben saw that his lip was bleeding.

Remorse set in directly; all his anger was gone, and Ben was miserable. He would have given all that he had now to live the last ten minutes over again. But that could not be; and Ben must reap what he had sown. He stood irresolute. The lady was beside him.

"Where do you live?" she asked, kindly. Something in the boy's sad face interested her, red and heated as it was with the last few minutes' work. That work had left its effect in Ben's face, and he held his handkerchief to a scratch on his cheek.

Ben glanced down the road where Kit stood waiting anxiously.

"There," he answered, pointing with his hand, "but I've a good mind to run away and never come back; I would in a minute if it wasn't for that little girl standing there. She would be awfully sorry, but I'm not fit to live in a place like that. You see, I can't keep my spirit down."

The lady put her hand on his shoulder, and drew him along with her towards Kit as she said—

"There is One who would help you, little boy, if you would ask Him."

The tears rolled down Ben's cheeks.

"That's the worst bit of all," he answered.

"How so, my boy?"

"Because He's been—so—good, and I've tried to do what He wants me to, and now I've spoilt it all."

They had reached the cottage gate, and Kit had slipped her hand into Ben's, and looked up wonderingly into the lady's face, while she drew some frightened sobs.

"Tell your mother I'm sorry, very sorry, Kit. I'll come back to you soon," said Ben, as he put Kit's hand gently on one side. "But I can't come in now;" and he nodded to the lady. He took a few quick steps forward, and was out of reach but not out of hearing as both cried after him, "Don't go away," and the stranger added, "Be a brave little soldier for Jesus, and don't run away."

But Ben, though he hesitated a moment, went on with rapid steps towards the country. Soon he began to run, and, after a few minutes, they lost sight of him. Then they went inside the cottage and found Mrs. Gray hushing baby Harry to sleep. She laid him down and then turned with surprise to hear what Mrs. Frankham had to tell of Ben and his fight with Jim Snow.

"I hope you will excuse me for intruding upon you," she said, "but I am really sorry for the little fellow. I believe he was teased by the big boy, for I had been watching them for some minutes; his temper got the better of him, but I think he is very grieved about it."

Mrs. Gray thanked Mrs. Frankham for coming in, and then told her all she knew of Ben's history, and how he had only been with her for a short time.

"He is a very wise little fellow, and so kind and willing. We are very fond of him, and should be sorry, indeed, if any harm came to him. But I think he'll come back, for the love he bears our Kittie," she said.

"Him said he'd come back," cried Kit, with quivering lip and eyes brimful of tears.

"So he will, dear. Don't fret," said her mother, "it isn't good for you."

Before Mrs. Frankham left, she said that when passing again she would like to call and speak a word to the little fellow, for she felt sure he was trying to do right from what he had said to her.

"You have taught him about the Lord Jesus, Mrs. Gray?"

"I sometimes think he has taught me more, for many a word he has said about Jesus has gone deep into my heart."

"Poor little fellow, he will be sorry; we have such a foe to contend with. Tell him, from me, that if he loves the Saviour he must take Him as his Captain, and He will give him strength to stand as a good soldier, and not to yield to Satan and be overcome."

CHAPTER VII.

BEN'S RETURN.

The afternoon passed wearily to little Kit and her mother, for Ben did not return. They went to the gate many times to look for him, and walked some way up the road, but Ben was not to be seen. Tea-time came, and Harry Gray returned. He was very vexed and disappointed.

"I hoped that we should be able to keep him and train him up well, for he gave good promise in many ways; it will be a pity if he goes back to the old place."

"Ben said he would come back, and him speaks true. Him's the *truest* boy, father," urged Kit. "Jesus can see him, and will make him come back."

"Your faith is strong, darling, I shall go out after tea, and try to find him."

But there was no need to go out after tea to look for him, for the next moment Kit was down from the table and had her arms round Ben's knees.

He had just lifted the latch of the kitchen door very gently and walked in. His face was quite calm, with a smile 'twixt hope and fear on it. Before Mr. and Mrs. Gray could speak he walked straight up to the mother.

"I'm awfully sorry I fought Jim this morning, and if you'll give me another chance I'll try and do better, though he mocks and laughs at me, and calls me 'Baby, in the low class,' I won't heed it. I want to be—to be what the lady said, 'A brave soldier for Jesus.' He never struck any one."

"That's right, Ben dear. It's all forgiven and forgotten—you won't do it again. We're glad to have you home," said the mother, with fast filling eyes.

And, holding out his hands to him, the father added, "Aye, we need to remember that He was mocked, and scourged, and crucified, and yet He never even threatened them, but prayed God the Father to forgive."

"I'll try hard, and do like Him," said Ben.

"Remember, boy, that when they laugh at you, if you *take it in fun* they'd soon stop. Suppose they call you a 'Baby in the low class,' if you could just turn round and say, 'I know I'm in the baby class, but it isn't my fault, and I don't mean to stay there'; it would be better and more kind if you helped me with my lessons.' If you said that, Ben, they would soon stop it."

"There's some sense in that," said Ben, shrewdly. "I'll try it to-morrow, though it will be very hard."

"I am afraid it will. When we do wrong, we must suffer; but I'll try and help you through it, lad."

"You are kind," replied the little fellow.

"He's the *kindest* father," echoed Kit, for which she was well kissed, and they all laughed.

"She was quite *sure* you would come back, Ben!"

"It was a good thing I *promised* her, for I never told her a lie; and when I got into the old barn, up the road far away, I thought I couldn't face any of you again, for I knew you would not approve of fighting ways; but I remembered what the lady, our teacher, said about being a brave little soldier for Jesus, and I thought: 'If they will try me again, I'll go back, because I could never leave my little Kit.' See, I nearly forgot what I had brought you, Kit."

"Oh—h! oh—h! the beau-fullist little bird," she cried, as Ben drew a little dead nestling from his breast pocket.

"But it's dead!—dead!" she added.

"It was up at the stream yonder. I went to give my face a wash after all the,—the,—you know what,—and the crying,—so I was having a good plunge when this little *bird* flapped along the ground, and was frightened at all my splashin' I suppose, for it fell in the water, and then it scrambled out, and flew right into a hole in the wall. I took off my stockings, and wading across lifted it out; but the little thing was nearly dead, and its heart was thumping at such a rate, and its beak kept opening and shutting till it died."

Kittie's eyes opened very wide while Ben was telling this, and her cheeks flushed crimson. She held the dead little thing so tenderly in her hands, while its tiny head fell over her fingers.

"I will keep it like this, the darling birdie," said the little girl; and all the evening long she would not give it up.

"We must bury it to-morrow, Kit, in your little garden. I'll make a little box for its coffin, and dig the hole."

But she stroked the pretty little yellow and brown feathers, and did not wish to think of to-morrow.

CHAPTER VIII.

SCHOOLBOYS.

When Ben woke next morning he had a great load on his mind, for he had to face the boys again; but after a few words with the father, he felt better; and taking Harry Gray's hand in the breakfast hour, they went together to Jim's home.

A knock at the door brought Mrs. Snow face to face with them.

"This little chap forgot himself yesterday, and when the boys mocked him for being put in the low class, he struck at your Jim. He is sorry for it, and wants to make up with him again."

"Jim came in with his lip cut, and I found out that your boy had done it. I suppose he has been used to that sort of thing, and we cannot expect much better from him. As he is sorry, it's all right this time; and I hope he will behave himself better another day."

"I never used to fight anybody," answered Ben. "It's hard for a fellow to be called 'baby' because no one taught him to read before; but I mean to try not to fight Jim again. You might ask him to leave off teasing me."

Mrs. Snow looked at the eager face before her, and her better feelings prevailed.

"Come here, Jim," she cried, diving at Jim, who was behind the door; "here's Ben Gray come to tell you he's sorry for fighting. It's more than you would do. Now don't you tease him again."

Jim struggled to get free, and bursting away, cried—"I'll pay him out; see if I don't."

Mrs. Snow's better feelings were quite overwhelmed now by her anger against Jim; and she went in search of him to promise him such a thrashing as he knew she would never carry out, while Harry Gray and Ben walked away.

"Don't be afraid, boy, persevere and think twice before you act," said the father, as they parted—the one for school, the other for work.

Of course Ben had a great deal to contend with; but when he had once tried the right way, every fresh attack from the boys was easier to withstand.

"That's the baby who had to go and beg Jim's pardon," said a close friend of Jim's to Ben on coming home from school the same day.

Ben's cheeks flushed and he bit his lips, then he turned to the boy—

"I am in the baby class," he said, "and it's enough to make you laugh to see such a big boy as I am there, but I'm not going to stay in it—I mean to try and get out in two weeks, and as you know such a lot you might help me to read. I did tell Jim I was sorry, and so I *am*, because I've made a *lot* of people sorry."

It was a great effort for Ben to say this, but it had its effect; the boy didn't know what to reply, and ran off.

After a few days the others left off teasing Ben about his lessons, for he was not afraid to own the truth,—and in a fortnight the master put him in another class. But Jim did not forgive Ben.

CHAPTER IX.

IN THE STORM.

It was just such another day as when the Sunday School children had played about in the meadows six weeks before. The rays of the sun were very hot, though a gentle breeze stirred the branches of the trees around. Far in the distance was a dark line of cloud, but it was so far away that one did not notice it.

Little Kit was looking rather pale; and when Ben ran in from school the mother said—

"You might take Kit for a ride in the perambulator, Ben. Be back in time for tea." She could trust him perfectly with Kit now, as he had proved himself very careful, and after tucking the little girl comfortably into the "coach," she put pieces of bread and jam into their hands, and they started off towards the country.

Ben was very anxious to show Kit a bird's nest he had discovered in a bush on the outskirts of a wood some distance away, but there would be plenty of time to reach the place and get back for tea, if they were quick. So he ran along the shady side of the road, pushing Kit merrily.

"The nest is empty now, Kit, but you'll like to see where the young birds were hatched. It was such a cosy warm place."

"Something like my little crib, Ben."

"Very much like that, Kit, and you look like a little bird yourself at night, with your head peeping out and your eyes shining bright like beads."

Kit laughed, "I wonder if angels watch over little birds at night?"

"Well—father said not one of them falls to the ground without God knowing it, so may be they are watched over. Folks say that little 'birds' praise Him by their singing; anyhow it sounds as if they chirped something solemn at night when the sun has gone down. I've heard them in that wood over there."

"It's nice to think of little birds thanking Him, isn't it?" said Kit.

"Yes; and we ought never to forget to thank Him also, for we've got far more nice things than they."

As they passed along the hedgerow and neared the wood, Jim Snow sprang out upon them with a howl which caused Kit to scream with terror, whereupon he set up his mocking laugh.

"I saw the young lady and her coachman coming along, and I thought I'd make her jump," he cried; "ha! ha!"

"How *could* you be so cruel, Jim? see how frightened she is," said Ben, indignantly. "Big boys like you ought not to frighten little girls. Never mind, Kit; he will not do it again."

"Don't you be too sure," cried Jim, as he disappeared behind the bushes.

It would have been wiser if Ben had turned homewards after this little affair, but he was so anxious to show Kit the bird's nest. He watched till Jim ran off to the little stream where he had found the nestling for Kit a short time before, and then wheeled her onwards. At the stream, Jim joined Eliza (his sister next in age to himself), who was in charge of a little girl about a year old. He spoke to her as if ordering her home, and then stopped to watch her proceedings for a few minutes. She had taken the shoes and socks off the baby and was going to teach it to walk in the water.

Poor little thing, it was grasped roughly round the waist, while its tiny feet were jumped up and down on the stones in the stream.

"I shan't go home till I've given Jane a bathe, shall I, darling?" Jane screamed, and Eliza shook her.

"I'm not going to stand any of that, so stop at once," she said, and, whilst trying to get a firmer hold of the child, it fell sideways into the stream.

Of course, Jane screamed louder, and Eliza took her or tugged her up the bank as best she could; all her little garments dripping with water.

"Won't you catch it," cried Jim, with a whistle.

"Don't tell, Jim, and I'll wring out her things, and they'll dry before I get home."

"Won't I though; you told about me the other day, didn't you? But I must be off, wishing you good luck," and he ran away in the direction Ben and

Kit had gone, leaving Jane to her fate.

Eliza did her utmost to dry the clothes, and all the way home was planning the best method of getting over her scrape, if her mother should find it out.

On went Ben with his little charge, quite unaware that they were both followed by Jim, who was very curious to know their proceedings. A short distance up the road, on the side of a hill, Ben came to a gate, which was attached to a post by a chain slipped over it; he raised this, and pushed the perambulator into the meadow, and, lifting Kit out, told her to take his hand, while he pushed the "coach" up the rising ground, past some straggling bushes.

"Now, we'll leave it here for a few minutes, Kit, while we scramble through this little hole in the fence into the wood, and you'll hear the birds sing, if you be quiet, and I'll show you the little nest Will Grant showed me. We mustn't stay many minutes, because I promised to be back before father comes home to tea. I'll take the shawl on my arm, in case you would like to sit on it."

They scrambled through the little hole, and Ben searched about for the bush. It was not so easy to find as he imagined, and it took him nearly a quarter of an hour before he hit on the right spot.

Kit did not mind the delay, for she was busy filling her hands with all sorts of weeds and leaves and flowers, to take home to her mother. At last the nest was found, which Will Grant had left hoping the bird might lay more eggs in it, and Ben lifted Kit to see it and feel it.

"What's that?" cried Ben.

They listened.

"Sounds like funder," said Kit.

A low distant roar was heard, which suddenly seemed to break over their heads. At the same moment a shrill whistle sounded near them, and a

tall man broke through the bushes.

"What are you doing here?" he asked. "Be off, sharp now. You are disturbing the beasts, and you're 'trespassing.'"

Ben started, and Kit clung to him.

"What beasts, please Sir? Are there any wild beasts about?" and Ben glanced round with a scared look.

"No, no, rabbits and hares, and such like, which we want kept quiet. Another thing is, traps have been set all over the wood, and if you got your legs caught in them, it would be awkward."

"It would never do for this little girl to get caught. Would you please tell us where they are, Sir?"

"Oh, all about; never come here any more. It takes all my time keeping the public off."

"We have nothing to do with 'publics.' Father and mother wouldn't allow us to go inside one, please Sir," said Ben secretly rather afraid of the tall man, and wishing to be civil.

"No, no; I was making no reference to the public houses," answered he, with a laugh. "I daresay you are decent little folks, but you ought not to be here. What did you come for?"

"I came to show this little girl a real bird's nest in a bush here, but I won't come again. You see, she was brought up in Peters Street and never saw one before."

"Hum! she's a pretty little thing, and you ought to take her home at once, there's a tempest coming on. See!" A flash of lightning lighted up the wood, showing up for an instant every leaf and branch; then followed a peal of thunder.

"It isn't safe to stay here; what are you going to do?"

"The 'coach' is just outside the fence, I'll put Kit in and run home."

The man hesitated; he had a kindly face when off duty; and the little pair touched a chord in his heart.

"If the storm is heavy, just stop at the little red brick cottage along the road; my wife stays there; tell her I sent you; I have to go a little further before I turn in."

He helped them through the bushes, saying, as he did so, "I can't think how you'll get along; the storm is going to be heavy; but you mustn't stay here."

"We were saying coming along that God takes care of sparrows, so He is sure to look after us. We are not afraid. You might have been awful cross with us for coming in this here wood, instead of that you are helping us, you see. It must be Jesus taking care of us."

"I wish I never had to deal with worse characters than you," said Michael Craig, for this was his name. "Go into the cottage as you pass. Good-bye."

Again the children scrambled through the little hole in the fence, and ran to the place they had left the perambulator; but to their dismay, it was gone.

CHAPTER X.

THE LITTLE RED HOUSE.

The scene around had changed during the half-hour.

Angry looking clouds were coming up on all sides, and heavy drops of rain were falling.

"What *shall* we do?" cried Ben. "Your coach has been stolen, Kit. What will they say at home? Oh dear—dear! Some tramps have got it. We must follow on, and perhaps we'll overtake it."

"I don't like the lightning, Ben," cried Kit.

"And this rain will soak you through; keep close up to the hedge a few minutes, while I wrap you in the shawl. It's a good thing I took that with us."

He wrapped Kit up as warmly as possible, and made her sit down behind him while he kept the rain off her as best he could. Tears of vexation rolled down his cheeks as he thought, "things seem to be all going wrong," and he absently put his hands in his pockets. Doing so, he laid hold of the two little texts Miss Randolphe had given him—"Jesus Christ, the same yesterday, to-day, and forever" (Heb. xiii. 8). Her words occurred to his mind—Yesterday means long ago when He died on the cross for us and put away our sin; To-day means now while He helps us along the narrow path; and Forever, when we will be with Him safe in heaven.

"All right," thought Ben, "if Jesus keeps the same, He won't forget *us*, but He'll help us safe through all this trouble we've got into. There's another flash, Kit! We mustn't stay here, it is not safe; I heard father say, people are struck dead under trees and such like when the lightning flashes. What was that! It sounded like some one crying out? Listen." But a peal of thunder drowned every other sound. "I suppose it was only my fancy. Now Kit, stand on that old tree—that's it, and put your arms round my neck, and I'll sling the shawl right over your head and bind you on my back, and run away home as fast as I can, then I'll come back and look after the 'coach.'"

Kit did as she was bid, and with his precious burden on his back, Ben ran as fast as he could down the hill. The rain pelted upon them, and the little boy panted for breath, but he struggled on till the little red cottage came in sight.

"We must try and get in here," he gasped, and upon reaching the door, he rapped.

A woman past middle age opened the door, and looked greatly surprised at seeing Ben with the little girl's head peeping out above his shoulders.

"Please let us in; the gentleman who walks in the woods to keep the public off, told us to come here till the thunder was over," cried Ben.

The woman drew the children inside the door, and asked them to walk in and dry themselves at the kitchen fire, while they told her all that had happened.

She had a sweet sad face, with grey banded hair, and though her dress was very plain, almost poor, yet it was very neat. A younger woman, with a baby in her arms, stood by the fire.

"It's an awful storm for such little children to be out in. Tell us all about it, my lad, and how you met our Michael!" said the elder woman, lifting Kit on her knee.

Thus encouraged, Ben began at the beginning and told all about the excursion, the bird's nest, the meeting with Michael, and the loss of the "coach."

The women were loud in their sympathy, and said it was a strange thing that it should be stolen so quickly.

"Directly I've taken little Kit home, I shall run and have another look round just in case someone has moved it and it is still somewhere about," said Ben.

"Yes, it would be worth while to do that," she answered.

While they were speaking, the sound of a hollow cough was heard in the next room, and a feeble voice asked—

"Who is that?"

"That's John," said the elder woman, rising and going towards the next room.

"Who is John? your little boy?" asked Ben.

"He was my little boy once, he's a big boy now, and he's very ill, but that would be nothing if I knew he was happy." She returned in a minute, saying, "John wanted to see the children; he has always been fond of children." Mrs. Craig lifted Kit up into the next room, and Ben followed.

The sick man lay on a little bed in one corner; everything around was comfortable and neat, and a few flowers stood beside him in a tumbler of water. His face was sallow and sunken, and his dark hair, which was long and straight, was brushed off his forehead; but he had a pleasant, kindly smile, and he greeted the children warmly.

"I was always fond of little children," he said, shaking his head from side to side, and speaking with difficulty, for his breath was short and troublesome. "The Lord said 'except ye become as little children.' I wish *I* could do that." He went on to speak to them as well as he was able, asking them how they were caught in the storm, and so on.

"They met Michael," said the mother, "and he sent them here. Michael has a kind heart though he speaks sternly when on duty."

Ben was standing by the window, and now and then casting anxious glances out at the storm, which seemed to be subsiding. Suddenly he ran towards the door crying, "There's father passing."

And so it was; Mr. Gray, with rapid strides, was passing up the hill, and heeding little the rain and storm.

"Call him in, he is looking for you, no doubt," said Mrs. Craig, and Ben ran out and brought him in. He, in his turn, was surprised, and very thankful to find the children safe.

Ben's heart beat very quick at the thought of the perambulator, and he anxiously waited the moment when he should speak of it. Meanwhile, Mr. Gray, after hearing about the children, was having a little talk with the mother, who was telling him about her sick son.

CHAPTER XI.

THE SICK MAN AND THE FALLEN FOE.

Mrs. Craig had taken a fancy to Gray at once. Something in his bright manly face had drawn out her confidence, and pointing to John on his sick bed, she said—

"I wonder if you could cheer up my poor lad a bit; he's not so happy as I would like."

"How's that?" he asked. "Does he not know the One above as his friend?"

"Ah, that's just what he wants, but you know the Lord, don't you? and I've asked Him to send some one here to speak to John, and now He's done it. He's been a good son to me, and he's served the Lord too, but he's not quite at peace now, you understand."

"How's that, my friend?" said Gray, sitting down at his bedside. "The Lord surely is faithful?"

"He is faithful," slowly answered the sick man, "but I haven't been—I was a wild one once, but I turned to the Lord—and I believe I found the Saviour—and I tried to serve Him—and I taught the young—I always loved the children—but something went wrong in the Sunday School and I turned off, and after that I wandered from Him somehow—I don't right know how. I haven't been faithful to Him, and I might have been a better son to *her*," pointing to his mother.

"Never heed that, John," said the mother, eagerly, "I've forgiven all that. You were always an obedient lad to me when you were at home."

"I must take the children away now, for the mother is anxious to hear tidings of them, but I'll come in again and perhaps send a friend who can speak to you better than I."

"We'll always make you welcome; be sure and come," said John, anxiously.

"All right; I'll step in to-morrow and see how you are getting on. Meantime, thank you for taking such kindly care of the children."

Harry Gray found it difficult to speak much about sacred things to others, but on turning to leave, he said to John, "Remember, friend, 'The Rock never moves'; that's a comfort to me," and shaking hands all round he started forth with the children.

The thought of the perambulator never occurred to Mr. Gray's mind, but poor Ben had not forgotten it. With a great effort he said—

"The coach is up by the wood, I think. I couldn't find it when I started in the storm, and I was afraid Kit would catch cold, so I carried her to the lady's house as quick as I could, but I want to run back to look for it. Can I go?"

"Whew—w! Let's hope the 'pram.' isn't lost, Ben. You must have been careless about it. Yes, run back, the storm is over now, and I'll come and meet you. Mother couldn't part with it."

No need to tell Ben to run; he scampered away as quick as his legs could carry him.

All the branches of the trees and hedges were dripping after the recent shower, and the air was fresh and sweet.

In a few minutes he reached the gate leading to the meadow, and the first object that met his eyes was the perambulator; the second object, Jim, sitting beside a bush, pale and frightened, his eyes swollen with crying. He was moaning and holding his knees with both hands, while he rocked backwards and forwards.

Ben bounded to the "coach" with an exclamation of surprise and gladness, and seized the handle as if to secure it from Jim, while he eyed him suspiciously.

"I suppose you interfered with Kit's carriage?" he cried, wheeling it off. "It was too bad, Jim, I had to carry her down the road. What did you do it for?"

"Stop that!" answered Jim, moaning again. "I was just having a bit of fun. It was safe enough, if you had only used your eyes better. Ah, dear! what will I do?"

Ben felt half inclined to run off with his recovered treasure, but a better feeling prompted him to wait, and ask what was the matter.

At first Jim did not reply, but upon Ben coming up to him, and asking if he were hurt, Jim broke down.

"I've hurt my knee, and I can't walk. Mother'll want to know where I am, and I shall never get home?"

"I could help you," said Ben; "put your arm in mine."

"It isn't a bit of good, I can't walk a step."

"Will you get in the coach? It is a very strong one, and I'll wheel you slowly," said Ben.

Jim hung his head sullenly. It was a very humbling thing for him to get on to Kit's carriage, and be pushed along by Ben, but it was the only thing to be done, and, though he felt very much ashamed when he remembered his past conduct, after pretending to object a little to the plan, he allowed Ben to help him on to the perambulator. It was a good-sized double one, and so, without much difficulty, though suffering a great deal of pain, he seated himself.

Very carefully did Ben wheel his vanquished enemy along, and very different were the feelings of the boys.

"I'm glad I've got the 'coach,'" said Ben. "Kit's mother *would* have been greatly upset if it had a been lost or stolen."

"It would not have been lost or stolen," answered Jim, "I only wheeled it back into the bushes for fun."

He did not say how the fun he had looked forward to, was to see the children search in vain, and commence their homeward walk in distress.

"It wasn't *real* fun," replied Ben. "When did you get your knee hurt?"

"I was up in a tree, and I fell down," he answered, shortly. "You won't sneak about it, will you?"

"No—no—o, but you had better tell the truth. I will not say how you vented your spite on Kit and me, but don't do it again, Jim. Kit's a real nice little girl."

"No, I won't; that's truth for once; especially if you don't sneak on me."

Jim did not tell how he climbed the tree to watch Ben's dismay at the loss of the coach, neither did he tell how a vivid flash of lightning alarmed him so that he hurried down too quickly and so fell on his knee. But he had been justly punished.

Harry Gray met them half way and guessed pretty much how matters stood. He spoke a word of stern, yet kindly warning to Jim, who was heartily glad when he reached his own home. He was carried in to make the best of the adventure he could. Ben, after a good tea, went very happily to bed.

CHAPTER XII.

WHAT A LITTLE CHILD CAN DO.

Mrs. Frankham often passed Ben on the road to and from school, and she always had a kindly smile for him, and sometimes a pleasant cheering word.

"Are you still trying to be a brave little soldier?" she asked the morning after the adventure in the wood. And when Ben answered with a nod—"Yes, ma'am, as hard as I can:" she replied—"That's right; the Good Captain is watching, and it will be worth all the trouble when we get His smile."

Ben gave her a pleased look.

"Please ma'am, I heard father say last night he wanted to speak to you about going to see a poor man, who is ill and is not happy. I think he is going to die. Do go and see him!"

"That I will most gladly: and will you go too?"

"If you'll let me," replied Ben, "I would like to go and take him some flowers—he likes flowers."

"I will come in after dinner, and speak to mother about it, Ben. By-the-bye, when does father come in—mid-day?"

"A quarter-past one till a quarter to two," replied the little boy.

"Very well, I will try to come then, and I shall bring some roses with me."

At the appointed time Mrs. Frankham called at Wood Cottage, and heard all that Harry Gray could tell about John Craig.

She was very much interested in the account of the family, and started off with Ben to pay them a visit. Mrs. Craig received her visitors very gladly.

"I am so anxious that poor John should get peace and rest in his Saviour, for I fear he has taken his father's complaint, and it may be he will never rise from his bed again. He is used to my words, and though he listens he seems to get little good; but from you perhaps the arrow will strike him."

"If the Lord guide it. I trust He will give the right word, my friend."

Mrs Craig led the lady and Ben into the neat little room, where John lay, and after speaking a few kind words to the sick man, Mrs. Frankham said "This little boy told me about you: he was so anxious I should come and speak to you: he has brought you some flowers, for he says you are fond of flowers."

"So I am," replied John, faintly, and eagerly taking them from Ben's hand, he put them in a little glass, where the fragrant smell reached him. "I like little boys too, I am so fond of little children."

Ben sat on a stool near the bed, and the sick man scarcely took his eyes off him for some minutes, not till he forgot everything else in his desire to lay hold of the Words of Life.

"What I want," said he, "is some one to speak to me of the Saviour. I have wandered from Him, and want to get back, if He will have me; but I sometimes wonder if He will."

"You doubt His willingness. Listen, His word says—'If we confess our sins, *He* is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and cleanse us from *all* unrighteousness' (1 John i. 9). *He* is faithful. We forget Him; He never forgets us. It is sad to grieve Him, but the only way is to confess it to Him, take a humble place before Him, and He will pardon for His own name's sake."

"Tell me more; I see it plainer now," said John; and as he spoke a fit of coughing racked his feeble frame.

Little Ben was sitting and watching first one and then the other intently.

Mrs. Frankham continued, "In order to get rest and peace we need to see that we were lost; could do nothing to save ourselves; but that Jesus stretched out a strong arm to save us. He undertook our cause, and bore our sin in His own body on the cross. *There* God punished sin. *There* Jesus put it away, and rose without it; and from heaven He offers a free pardon to all who flee to Him—who put their trust in Him."

A smile lighted up the face of the sick man, and he forgot himself and his unfaithfulness, and began to praise the Saviour. After a few more words, Mrs. Frankham said—

"Can you rest in His love now?"

"Yes; I can," he replied.

"Don't look into yourself then, but fix your eye on Him. Shall we pray together before we part?"

"Yes, I was turning round for it," he said, trying to change his position in the bed.

The lady prayed that Satan's fiery darts might be quenched by the poor sufferer keeping up the shield of faith, and that his eye might be fixed on Jesus.

Then Ben and she left, both promising to come back again the next afternoon.

The little boy was much concerned about poor John, and very anxious to know that he was going to live with Jesus in heaven.

Next morning he rose early, and going into the field, plucked a posy of the best wild flowers he could, and then set off to Mrs. Craig's cottage and left them with her, for poor John.

The old mother was delighted with the little boy's thoughtfulness, and she asked him in to see her son, who was also glad to speak a few kind words to Ben, and thank him heartily for the flowers.

"I should like something with a strong smell," he said. "It refreshes me."

Ben returned and searched the garden until he found a piece of Southernwood, or "old man," as it is called. Then, after school, he watched for Mrs. Frankham, and, all excitement, he cried out as soon as he saw her at the gate, "The poor sick man wanted a bit of something sweet, and I've

got a bit of 'old man.' Come and see him. Do come and tell him more; I want to see him again."

"I thought of going on a little farther first, Ben," she said smiling; but as he urged her to go at once, she consented, and they set off to the little red cottage.

Again a warm welcome was given, and John held the Southernwood between his hands, that the scent might revive him, while Mrs. Craig took Ben into the next room to show him some of John's attempts at painting, of which the mother was very proud. Mrs. Frankham told John of Ben's anxiety to come and see him, and how he wanted to know that his soul was safe.

The young man seemed much struck with the little child's desire, and it greatly pleased him.

"Satan has been trying to tempt me to doubt, but my Saviour is near, and now if it pleases Him to take me I am both ready and willing to go."

He spoke of his own worthlessness, and the Saviour's love, and pointed to a text which had been given him, "Whosoever will, let him take the water of life freely" (Rev. xxii. 17).

He never doubted his Saviour's love and power again; instead, the blessed name of Jesus was ever on his lips till he was called home about a fortnight later.

Little Ben was very glad that John was gone to be with Jesus, and after this he was a frequent visitor at Mrs. Craig's. They liked to have him there, and Michael took a great interest in the boy. Many a ramble did Ben get in the wood, by the gamekeeper's side; he knew how to escape the traps he had once feared, and Michael liked to hear him talk and repeat his little texts. "Jesus Christ the same yesterday, to-day, and for ever" (Heb. xiii. 8), was still a great favourite with him.

Mrs. Craig did sorrow of course, but she was very glad and thankful that her son had gone home so happily, and she was very grateful to Mrs.

Frankham for coming so many times to see him. Harry Gray, and his wife too, had stepped in several times and read passages from the Word of God to him. Michael was often away when the visitors called, but the death of his brother had had a great effect on both him and his wife, and they seemed anxious to hear the truth.

CHAPTER XIII.

A VISIT TO THE SEA.

One day in the end of August, a happy little party landed at a sea-side place from one of the river steamers on the Thames. The children had never seen the sea before, and great had been the wonder expressed as they ran about the deck of the steamer,—now watching the rippling water, and the white foam caused by the paddle wheels,—now throwing bits of bread to the birds as they followed in the wake of the steamer.

The little party consisted of Mrs. Craig, Michael, his wife and three children, and of Mr. and Mrs. Gray, Ben, Kit, and Harry.

Harry was now a fine, strong boy, and able to run about.

After they landed, the mother and children sat on the beach, while Michael and Harry went in search of their lodgings. Both families had engaged rooms in the same row of cottages, and were within three minutes' walk of each other and close to the sea.

Quite a friendship had been formed between them since John's death, and when Harry Gray proposed a week's visit to the sea, they fell in with it at once. The fathers could only stay from the Saturday till Wednesday, and return and fetch their families home, but all were in high spirits at the prospect of a few days' holiday, and Ben and Kit were not among the least delighted.

School discipline had very much improved Ben. He had dropped his rough words, was beginning to read very well, and could write a little too, and Mr. Goodall promised to take him as his message boy in October, if he continued to make progress.

Mr. Goodall had a shop of stationery, fancy goods, desks, work-boxes, trinkets, and better class ornaments. So Ben was very anxious to get on with his lessons, and looked forward eagerly to again earning his living.

Little Kit was fast losing her pale cheeks and thin limbs; a nice colour often showed in her face, and her arms and hands were getting quite plump and brown. Her father and mother could scarcely bear her out of their sight, she was the light of their eyes. Ben was often astonished at the fun and spirit she showed; though she was quiet and gentle at times, yet occasionally she made them all merry with her funny ways and lively pranks.

The morning after their arrival at the sea, the little party were grouped upon the sand, the elder ones for the most part watching the children's enjoyment, and helping them to build up sand-houses, make heaps and holes, and fill their buckets with the salt water. What a change this for the two little ones who, for almost all their lives had known no other pleasures than those to be found in Peters Street! After a while the children—Ben, Kit, Willie, and Nellie Craig—ran off to a piece of sand some little distance away, and the parents began talking together.

They spoke of the one who was gone, and of his happiness with the Lord Jesus. The poor old mother shed some tears, but they were not those of rebellion; she rejoiced to know that her son was beyond all sorrow and pain, and she was glad not to have "to leave him behind her," when her call came. Michael being "off duty" had left his "stern" look behind, and was much enjoying a lounge on the beach. He had felt the loss of his brother keenly, and had found great comfort in the friendship of Harry Gray, who was able to point to "John's Saviour."

The two young mothers found plenty to talk about, as they sat with their babies beside them. They spoke of past joys and sorrows, of little ones gone

before—for each had lost a child—and of the different tempers and dispositions of those left under their care.

"We thought our Kittie had neither temper nor faults, for some time after we found her, but now that her health is coming back, we find out she is a bit quick like the rest."

"It is better they should have a little spirit, though it needs checking," replied Mrs. Craig.

In the midst of their conversation they were startled by a cry from Kit, and in a moment Michael and Harry were on their feet. The children had been busy digging, and had not noticed that the tide on coming in had formed quite a little island of the piece of sand on which they were playing.

When little Kit lifted her eyes and saw herself surrounded by water, she was very frightened; and her sharp cry caused the two boys to look up, and the two men to rise to their feet. The water was running quickly round the island of sand, and every instant reduced it in size. Harry Gray and Michael took off their boots as quickly as possible, and ran to relieve the little company. One caught up Kittie and Willie, and the other, Nellie; Ben, who was tugging away at his boots trying to get them off, waded through the water with them; and by the time they reached dry land, the island had disappeared.

"I fort we was going to be drowned, and never see you any more, father," sobbed Kit, as she clung to his neck.

"No fear, my darling, while I am here," he answered.

"You will have to watch when the water comes in, children," said the mother laughing, as she received Kit from her father; "and now I think you had better all take off your shoes and socks, and wade in the sea."

This proposal was quickly agreed to, and in a few minutes the children were paddling away. Kit and Willie were a little shy at first, but soon got up their courage, and splashed away like the little ones around them; and baby

Harry had his little legs rubbed with the salt water, and seemed quite to enjoy it.

Willie Craig was rather a rough little boy; he had been humoured and spoiled by his mother while very small, and now she often found it difficult to control him. While wading, he filled his hands with salt water and flung it over Ben. The water ran down Ben's neck, and he turned round with an annoyed face to tell Willie to stop. But Kit, who stood near, took it upon herself to correct Willie for teasing her "bestest boy," and, to the surprise of all, leaned forward and administered a hearty slap on Willie's back, but at the same time she overbalanced herself and fell into the water.

Ben had her out in a moment, but all her clothes were wet, and little Kit was very much frightened, both at what she had done to Willie and the wetting she had got. Her lip quivered with her sobs, and she was in much distress.

"You are unfortunate this morning," said Michael, kindly.

"It will do her no harm," said her father, laughing.

"But Kittie was in a temper, I fear," added mother, "and that was the cause of her fall."

Father opened his eyes very wide and whistled. "Kittie in a temper! That's something quite new. What have little girls to do with tempers?"

"Oh, nothing at all," said Mrs. Craig, "and I'm sure Kittie did not mean it. Willie is very rough at times."

Kit hung down her head and began to cry, and Ben, though he was very much surprised to see her raise her little hand against anyone, yet came at once to her help. He put his arms round her.

"She didn't like to see me being splashed; she loves me that much, for she had only me at one time, and she forgot it was wrong, didn't you, Kit? You'll see she'll make it up with him and be friends in a minute."

Kit raised her blue eyes full of tears, and put up quivering lips to kiss Willie Craig, who, in his turn, was quite ashamed.

And so Kit's first quarrel was made up, and her mother took her home to change her clothes, for they were wet through.

"I didn't think Kit had such a spirit," said her father. "It shows she is getting stronger though," he added, with some satisfaction.

"Does it?" asked Ben, eagerly. "Hoor-ay!" and he went head over heels along the sand, to the amusement of the rest of the party.

They spent an hour or two during the afternoon in an open boat on the sea. The children dipped their hands in the water, while Harry and Michael sang to them, and then they all joined in a hymn, and enjoyed the sweet sea-breeze which fanned their faces as the sun began to sink in the sky.

CHAPTER XIV.

A SUNDAY EVENING AT THE SEA-SIDE.

On Sunday evening as they were taking a stroll, they observed a little crowd of people collected on the green sward above the cliffs.

On drawing near they found that a young man was reading from the Word of God. The little party of women and children seated themselves on a grassy mound to listen, while Harry and Michael stood among the people. With a clear distinct voice the preacher sounded forth the words, "Seek ye the Lord while He may be found; call ye upon Him while He is near!" (Isaiah lv. 6). "Behold, now is the accepted time, behold now is the day of salvation" (2 Cor. vi. 2).

Then closing the book he spoke to the young around him, those in health and strength. He told them Christ was waiting to save them in patient

grace. He was offering them salvation without money and without price, for He had paid the debt they owed to a holy God.

He told them they were sinners and not fit to stand before God without being washed in the blood of Christ. "But," he added, "the blood has been shed, and God offers you a free pardon to-day, if you will put your trust in it."

After he had invited his hearers, lovingly and earnestly, to cast themselves on Jesus just as they were, he began to show them what the consequences would be if they refused. "The Lord Jesus will Himself shut mercy's door one day," he said, "and then if you refused Him while in life and health, it will be TOO LATE. You will have to stand and knock at that closed door and cry, 'Oh, let me in; Lord, Lord, open to me,' and He will answer, 'I never knew you, depart from me.' There will be no hope for you then, though you cry ever so loud, or ever so long, and nothing will be left for you but ever-lasting woe. 'Behold! NOW is the accepted time; behold, NOW is the day of salvation.'" Then he went on to say that once a vessel was wrecked in a dreadful storm, and the captain and his wife were cast upon a small rock not far from land. They knew that unless they were soon rescued they must perish, for the waves were rising higher and higher, and would soon sweep them from the rock. They were, however, discovered, and strong men threw out a rope to help them, which the captain tied round his wife's waist, and showed her at a given signal she must leap upon the wave and it would bear her in to shore—that the sailors would be able to draw her to land.

It was her only chance. But she did not embrace it. Her husband urged her to leap, but she let the right moment go past, and leaped upon the wave when past, being engulfed by the one following it, and so was dashed upon the rock and killed.

Again the speaker urged his hearers to beware of letting the present moment pass. "You may not see another, or Satan may pluck the good seed out of your heart as you turn away from this spot. 'Seek ye the Lord while He may be found; call ye upon Him while He is near.'"

Many who listened were deeply stirred. Some had never been so urged before to come to Jesus, and little children (for little children are always foremost in a crowd) turned up grave and eager faces to the speaker. Then he said a word to them. He told them that the Saviour loved the little ones, and had invited them to come to Him; that Jesus had said "Suffer little children and forbid them not, to come unto Me, for of such is the kingdom of heaven" (Matt. xix. 14).

The three little ones listened very attentively, and the elder folk were much solemnized. Some that stood there had tasted a Saviour's pardoning love, and to them the gospel words were sweet. Others had never, till lately, thought seriously over these things, and now conscience was speaking loudly, and the little word "now" rung in their ears.

Along the cliffs and past the corn fields the Craigs and Grays wended their way. The setting sun threw bright golden and crimson rays on all around, while the ocean lay calm as a lake beneath them. Little Ben and Kit had never seen such a lovely sight, and as they walked along hand in hand they wondered "how heaven could be more beautiful than this."

A day or two after the scene was completely changed, however. Driving rain fell, a chill east wind blew, the sky was cloudy, and the sea was rough. In heaven, however, chilly blasts and clouds will never come, "for the former things are passed away" (Rev. xxi. 4); there it will be an endless summer of love and joy.

CHAPTER XV.

KITTIE IN TROUBLE.

A year has gone. Autumn has come again, and changes have taken place during that time at Wood Cottage. A little baby sister arrived for Kittie, and she was very happy in the possession of her new treasure. Baby Ella was

now three months old, and Kittie often held her in her arms for a few minutes, when mother was busy. Harry was now at the age when he was continually in mischief; but he dearly loved his sister Kittie, and was a nice little playmate for her.

Ben had been nine months at Mr. Goodall's as shop and message boy, and was getting on well. He earned sufficient to keep himself in clothes now.

But there had been an anxious time, too, at Wood Cottage; for one day the father had been injured at the wood-yard, and had been brought home in a cab, with a broken leg, and a slight cut on his head.

This happened about six weeks after baby Ella's birth, and it was quite a shock to Mrs. Gray; for the cab drove up to the garden gate while she was hanging out some clothes. Two men lifted her husband out, and his white pale face filled her with dismay.

But the doctor assured her his injuries were not dangerous, and with care he would be back at work in six weeks' time.

Every care was bestowed on him; but six weeks had passed, and he was not able to resume his work yet, for he had sustained a shock that it was not easy to get over. Ben wheeled a large chair into the garden every morning after breakfast when fine, and here the father sat, well wrapped up, for an hour or two in the sunshine. He was very anxious to get back to his work, and hoped to be able to do so in another week. Meanwhile, Ben was a great help at home. As soon as he was back from his work, he would throw off his jacket, and turn his hand to anything that eased the mother.

He was not above doing many things to aid her in the house; and she looked forward gladly to the time he could return of an evening, for he could nurse Baby Ella, and wash and dress Harry or put him to bed; and when the evenings were fine, he took them very nice rambles, while Mrs. Gray got on with her sewing.

One day Harry Gray had been limping slowly up and down the garden, and then sat down at the further end on a log of wood which lay there.

After a few minutes he heard a sharp cry, and turning his head saw Kittie and Harry rolling on the ground by the kitchen door. They had evidently had a fall. He could not rise quickly, so the mother was first on the spot. She raised the children up, and found that Harry had cut his forehead and hurt his knee, while Kittie had only grazed her arm.

"This comes of disobedience," said Mrs. Gray, gravely, looking at Kittie as she led her, and carried the little boy into the house.

"What is it all about?" asked the father.

"Kittie has been disobedient," she answered, as she soothed Harry's cries and prepared to bathe his forehead.

"I am sorry for that; come and tell me about it, Kittie."

Kittie was sobbing piteously and holding her arm. It was two or three minutes before she could reply:

"Mother told me not to lift Harry, and I tried to carry him down the steps, and we both toppled down."

"You see, father, Kittie is always trying to carry Harry, and he is far too heavy for her, and they have fallen once or twice. This morning I forbade her to do it again, but she has disobeyed, and you see the consequence. I told her I should punish her if she lifted him again; and, as she has done so, she must take her tea alone to-night; and see how poor Harry is hurt, too!"

"How came you to be so disobedient, Kittie?" asked her father.

"I forgot, father, and I wanted to lift him down the steps," sobbed the little girl.

"But you said that before, Kittie. Little girls must not forget. Perhaps father will take little Harry up the garden now; you had better stay here, we cannot speak to you till after tea."

Father looked lingeringly back as he led Harry away, but he knew mother was right, and Kittie had been growing rather thoughtless lately; so

he only said, "I am sorry."

Of course Kittie was very miserable, and she did not know how to keep quiet. "Mother, speak to me; don't look grave," she kept saying, and when she found her mother did not answer, she said, "and I s'pose God is angry too, and now there is a black spot made on my heart. What shall I do?"

"I am not *angry*, Kittie," replied her mother, "only very sorry, and you know what washes sin away, you know Whom to go to. But I cannot talk to you now."

"I am going to tell Jesus all about it, mother. Can I kneel down?"

"Oh! yes," replied her mother. So Kittie slipped off her chair and sobbed and prayed, and her mother caught the words, "Wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow."

CHAPTER XVI.

BEN'S PRESENT.

Soon Ben came in, and missing the little girl at the gate, cried, "Where's Kittie?" Mrs. Gray looked towards the chair where she sat, and Kittie's tear-stained face told the story.

"You haven't been naughty, have you. O Kit! What is it, mother?"

"She has been lifting Harry again, and both have fallen, and he has got hurt. You've heard me tell her not, Ben, many times; now she has to sit there and no one is to speak to her, and"—Mrs. Gray hesitated. She dreaded carrying out the rest of the punishment.

"And me's to have tea all alone," cried Kit.

"Oh! what a pity!" said Ben, "O mother! isn't she sorry enough?"

"She is sorry, I believe; but you must not beg her off, Ben," and Mrs. Gray made ready a plate of bread and butter and a mug of milk and carried them into the other room, saying, "Come, Kittie."

Kittie followed, and Ben looked very forlorn. Mrs. Gray put her up at the table in the little sitting room.

"Do you love me?" asked Kittie.

"Dearly," said her mother.

"Now?" she asked again in surprise.

"Yes, now."

"When I'm naughty?"

"Yes, but's it's a sorrowful kind of love."

"Then, I'll never be naughty any more," said Kittie, clasping her mother's neck.

"I hope not, darling," said the mother. "Have you asked God to help you to be obedient?"

"Yes, and to 'wash me whiter than snow,' and He's done it, hasn't He, mother?"

"He has, dear. He always answers when we pray aright. Now you must take your tea quietly, and then come and get a kiss from father."

"Have you *forgiven* me?" asked the little girl anxiously.

"I have, dear."

"Is she all right, mother?" asked Ben eagerly.

"Quite," answered the mother, with fast-filling eyes, "but I thought you were going to make some toast, Ben?"

"So I was, but I can't do a thing when Kit isn't happy. You know I never could," bending down to kiss baby in her cradle.

They gathered round the tea table, but Ben ate nothing. After a few minutes he asked, "How long is Kittie to stay there?"

"Till she has finished her tea," said mother, with a longing look at the other door, which stood open, and from inside of which they heard deep drawn sighs.

"May I see if she has finished?" asked Ben, starting up.

"I think he might, dear," added the father.

Ben was off in a twinkling.

"The boy is eating nothing, and we've kept our word," added Gray.

"So we have, and she's very sorry. She may come now."

"Kittie not hurt me again, she not mean it," lisped Harry.

"Have you finished your tea, Kittie?" asked Ben.

"Yes, it's all done," she answered, eyeing Ben to see what he thought.

"And you are sorry, Kittie. You won't try and lift Harry again, not till you are bigger, because mother says 'no,' and mother knows what is best."

"I'll try and never be naughty not any more, Ben."

"It grieves Jesus, you know?"

"Yes, and makes black stains on my heart, but this one is washed away, Ben; I asked Him to make me whiter 'an snow, so it's gone."

"I'm so glad; now come and kiss father, and I'll show you something."

Father was only too glad to give the kiss, and then Ben brought out a present for Kit, and handed her a neat little testament.

"I've got one, too; you see, I've been working extra hard lately, and Mr. Goodall has been more about the shop, because its 'stock-taking,' so to-day he called me in, and told me to choose a book for myself, and I said 'a testament for Kit, please,' so he gave me these two—one for each of us."

Kittie was delighted, and felt the responsibility too, of having God's Word in her possession.

"Please write our names in, and a text," said Ben, "and put in Kit's 'with Ben's best love.'"

"And put in Ben's 'with Kit's best love,'" echoed Kittie.

"Yes, do?" added Ben.

The father wrote, in both books, their names and a text. In Kittie's it was, "Jesus said, 'Suffer little children to come unto Me'" (Matt. xix. 14), and in Ben's, "Jesus Christ, the same yesterday, to-day, and for ever" (Heb. xiii. 8).

And now we must say "Good-bye" to the little ones. Ben worked hard at his place and earned his master's esteem, and he knew no greater pleasure than to bring home his wages to his kind guardians. He had many a difficulty to face, but he learned to look up and depend upon One who was ever ready to help him. His own father, Rogers, was lost at sea about two years after he resumed his sea-faring life, and so Ben ever looked upon Mr. and Mrs. Gray as his parents after this. The love that sprung up between him and little Kit, when in poverty, continued unabated, and he was proud, as time went on, to make her many a nice present, while she learned to sew and mend for him.

I am sorry to say Jim Snow did not improve much. True, he did not tease Ben any more, but he went with bad companions, and one Sunday he

and two other lads were drowned in the river, while boating.

This had a great effect on Ben, and made him shun idle boys, while he thought much on that verse which Miss Randolphe gave him as a remembrance: "To him that *overcometh*, will I give to eat of the tree of life, which is in the midst of the Paradise of God." (Rev. ii. 7). He found kind and lasting friends in the Craigs, and the old lady, especially, always made him welcome, while Michael and his wife showed an increasing interest in the things of God. The occupants of the little red cottage and those of Wood Cottage became fast friends, and many happy evenings were spent at both cottages. On these occasions the hard times of early days would often be recalled and their praises would ascend to the Lord Jesus for His great love to them in giving Himself to save them from sin and for all His interest in their eternal welfare and His watchfulness over their lives while down here. They had all trusted in Jesus and were indeed

SHELTERED AT LAST.

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